



Whose voice is this?

Who decided, in your life, what counts as success?

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

*This ebook is a self-knowledge
resource. It does not replace
therapeutic support.*

1. The measuring stick you never chose

There is a measuring stick in your life.

You cannot see it, but you feel it. It is always present: when you compare yourself, when you evaluate yourself, when you decide whether what you did was enough or not. It is there when you receive a compliment and automatically think "but it could have been better." It is there when you look at another woman's life and feel that tightening in your chest, that contraction that is not exactly envy, but something worse: the feeling that you are behind. It is there when you wake in the middle of the night with your heart beating fast, not because of a real crisis, but because of an inner voice telling you that you are not doing enough. That you are not being enough.

The measuring stick measures everything. It measures your work, your body, your motherhood, your home, your money, your relationships, your time. It measures what you produce and what you do not produce. It measures what you say and what you leave unsaid. It even measures what you feel, because there are emotions the measuring stick approves (determination, gratitude, ambition) and emotions the measuring stick rejects (tiredness, anger, doubt). And you, without noticing, adjust. You

swallow the tiredness, hide the doubt, transform the anger into more action. Because the measuring stick does not tolerate stopping. The measuring stick demands that you continue.

But I want to ask you a question. A simple question that we rarely ask ourselves.

Whose is this measuring stick?

Who placed it there? Who decided the measurements? Who defined where "enough" ends and "not enough" begins? Who drew the line above which you can breathe and below which you must run faster?

Was it you?

If the honest answer is "I don't know," that is all right. Most of the women I know do not know. And they do not know because the measuring stick was placed so early, so silently, so naturally, that it became confused with reality. It seems "the way things are." It seems objective truth. It seems the only possible criterion. But it is not. It is a measuring stick. And someone built it. And most likely, it was not you.

I want to tell you a story. Inês (fictional name, real pattern) came to me after having achieved everything she had set out to do in life. She had a management position at a multinational. She had a salary that most peo-

ple would consider excellent. She had a beautiful home, two healthy children, a stable marriage, holidays abroad twice a year. She had everything that was on the list. And the list was almost entirely crossed off.

When she sat in front of me, she said something I hear with a frequency that unsettles me: "I should be happy. I have everything. And I cannot understand why I feel this way."

I asked her: "This way how?"

And she went silent for a long time. Not because she did not know the answer. But because she had no words for something she had felt for years and never named. Finally she said: "Empty. I feel empty. And I feel ashamed to say it, because how can someone with my life feel empty?"

Inês was not depressed, in the clinical sense. She functioned. Brilliantly, in fact. No one around her suspected anything. She was the woman who solved things, who delivered, who organized, who held everything together. The woman everyone admired. But inside, there was a profound disconnect between what her life showed and what she felt. As if she lived inside a beautiful photograph but was not part of the image.

And when we began to explore what "success" meant to Inês, something interesting happened. I asked her to describe success without using words like title, money, recognition, or status. And she could not. She went blank. As if, without those categories, the concept dissolved.

I then asked her: "When you were ten years old, what did 'doing well in life' mean?"

And there the answer came immediately: "Having a good job, earning well, not depending on anyone, being respected." Word for word, it was her father's definition. The father who worked his entire life in a factory and said, every night at dinner: "Study, so you don't have the life I have." The father who measured a person's worth by the degree they held and the salary they earned. The father who never said "be happy" but said a thousand times "be someone."

And Inês became someone. Exactly in her father's terms. She studied, she climbed, she earned, she achieved. She crossed every item off the list that her father had given her without ever having given it to her. And when the list was almost entirely crossed off, she felt empty. Because the list was not hers. The measuring stick was not hers. The definition of success she had pursued for thirty years belonged to a man who loved her deeply but who only knew how to love in one way: by projecting onto her everything he could not be.

Inês did not need more achievements. She needed a new measuring stick. One that was hers. But before she could build it, she needed to see something she had never seen: that the old measuring stick was not "reality." It was her father's voice. Internalized, naturalized, confused with truth. So much a part of her that it seemed like her. But it was not.

This is what happens to most of us. We did not choose the measuring stick. We received it. And we received it so early that we confused it with ourselves. We believe that our criteria are ours. That our priorities are ours. That our definition of success is ours. But if we stopped, if we truly stopped and asked "where did this come from?", we would discover that most of the criteria by which we measure ourselves were planted by others. By parents, by school, by culture, by the era, by social media, by the people we loved and who loved us in the only way they knew.

And there is no malice in this. It is not a conspiracy. Most parents who plant measuring sticks in their children do so out of love. They want to protect them, prepare them, give them what they never had. But the result is the same: the child (or, more often, the daughter) grows up with a definition of success that is not hers. And she spends her life pursuing it. And when she achieves it, she feels empty. Because she reached someone else's goal. And her own, the truly hers, was left unlive.

If you recognize yourself in this, I want to tell you something you should have heard a long time ago: there is nothing wrong with you. The emptiness you feel is not ingratitude. It is not lack of effort. It is not lack of anything. It is the natural consequence of living with a measuring stick that is not yours. Of measuring yourself by criteria you did not choose. Of pursuing a definition of success that was decided before you were old enough to disagree.

And the first step toward changing this is not doing more. Not trying harder. Not finding a better strategy. It is stopping and asking, perhaps for the first time with genuine curiosity: whose is this measuring stick? Who decided, in my life, what counts as success?

If the question makes you uncomfortable, that is a good sign. Because discomfort is the sound of truth knocking at the door.

There is something more I want to name before we go further. And it is this: the measuring stick you did not choose is not just an abstract idea. It is a structure that organizes your entire day. The way you wake up (with urgency or with presence), the way you work (with compulsion or with choice), the way you rest (or do not rest), the way you evaluate yourself at the end of the day (by what you did or by what you felt). All of this is measuring stick. The measuring stick defines not only what you pursue, but how you live every hour. And the woman who lives un-

der a measuring stick that is not hers does not only have the wrong goals. She has the wrong relationship with her entire life. Because the measuring stick contaminates everything. It tells her that resting is laziness. That feeling is weakness. That hesitating is incompetence. That asking for help is failure. And she obeys. Every day. Without questioning. Because no one ever told her the measuring stick was questionable. No one ever told her the measuring stick was a choice. They told her the measuring stick was reality. And she lived as if it were.

But if you are reading these words, something in you already knows that it is not. Something in you already feels that another measure is possible. A measure that is yours. And that something, however small it may seem, is where everything begins.

2. Who defined your success

There is a reason why the question "whose is this measuring stick?" is so difficult to answer. It is because the measuring stick was not handed to you at a specific moment. There was no ceremony, no contract, no day when someone sat in front of you and said: "Attention, I am now going to install in you the definition of success you will pursue for the next few decades." If it had been that explicit, you would have had the chance to refuse. Or at least to question.

But it was not like that. The measuring stick was given to you in the most silent and effective way possible: it was given to you as if it were real. Not as an opinion, not as a choice, not as one possibility among many. It was given to you as the way things are. And when something comes to us as objective truth, we do not question it. We simply live inside it.

It begins in the family. Long before school, long before culture, long before social media. The first measuring stick comes from home. And it comes not so much through what parents say, but through what they value. Through what they celebrate and what they ignore. Through what provokes a smile and what provokes silence.

The father whose face lights up when his daughter brings home good grades, but who stays neutral when she tells him she spent the afternoon playing. The mother who says "I am proud" when her daughter is the best in the class, but who says nothing when her daughter simply is. The family where money is spoken of with respect and art with suspicion. The family where those who "made it" are celebrated and those who "fell behind" are mourned. All of this is measuring sticks being installed. Silently. Effectively. Without anyone being aware of doing it.

A child has no filters. She does not have the capacity to look at her father and think: "This is his perspective, based on his experiences, his wounds, his limitations. I will reflect and decide whether I agree." A child simply absorbs. What the father values becomes valuable. What the mother approves becomes good. What provokes love becomes desirable. What provokes rejection (or, worse, indifference) becomes dangerous. And so, layer by layer, the definition of success is constructed. Not with words. With atmospheres.

Then comes school. And school adds a new layer, perhaps the most destructive of all: quantified comparison. In the family, the measuring stick was implicit. At school, it becomes explicit. There are grades. There are rankings. There are the best and the worst. There are honor rolls and

there are parent meetings where a child's worth is reduced to a grid of numbers. And the child learns something she will never unlearn: your worth is measurable. And it is measured in comparison with others.

It does not matter if you scored seven. What matters is whether the class average was six or eight. Because seven alone means nothing. Seven only gains meaning when compared. And there is born the compulsive comparing that will accompany the woman for the rest of her life. The compulsion to look sideways before looking inward. To ask "how am I doing compared to the others?" before asking "how am I doing compared to myself?"

Culture comes next. And culture is the most invisible of all measuring sticks, because it is so broad, so encompassing, so omnipresent, that it does not even seem like a measuring stick. It seems like "the air." Culture tells you that a successful woman is financially independent. That she is slim but not too slim. That she is ambitious but not too ambitious. That she is a devoted mother and a brilliant professional. That she "makes things happen." That she "does not give up." That she has an organized home and a disciplined body and a full agenda and a social media presence that inspires without apparent effort.

And you look at this and think: "That is how it is. That is what is expected." But that is not how it is. That is what this culture, in this historical moment, in this corner of the world, decided to value. Fifty years ago, female success meant something else. A hundred years ago, something completely different. Fifty years from now, it will mean something else again. The cultural measuring stick changes. But while you are inside it, it seems eternal. It seems the only one.

And now come social media. And social media do something that no other measuring stick has ever done: they make comparison permanent, global, and curated. You no longer compare yourself with your neighbor, your colleague, your sister. You compare yourself with thousands of women whose lives you see only in the edited version. The version where everything works, everything flows, everything is beautiful. The version where effort is invisible and the result is impeccable.

And your brain, which does not distinguish between reality and a curated image, does what it has always done: it compares. And it concludes that you are behind. That you are falling short. That your life should be different. That you should have more, be more, appear more.

I want you to see the accumulation. The family gives you the first measuring stick: "Success is this." School adds: "And it is measured in comparison with others." Culture piles on: "And a successful woman is like

this." Social media reinforces: "And look, all the others have already gotten there." And you live inside four overlapping measuring sticks, each reinforcing the others, each tightening a little more the space where you can simply be.

And the worst part is that no one did this to you on purpose. Your parents loved you and wanted the best for you (within their definition of "best"). Your teachers were trying to prepare you for the world (within their definition of "preparation"). Culture and social media are not even conscious entities: they are systems, patterns, currents. No one conspires. Everyone contributes. And the result is a woman who measures herself by criteria she never chose and who believes, deeply, that those criteria are hers. That they are natural. That they are the only way to measure a life.

There is an exercise I do frequently with women who come to my work. I ask them to write, without thinking too much, ten things they consider "success." And then I ask them to look at the list and mark, with radical honesty, which of those things are really theirs. Which were born inside them. Which they would feel as success even if no one knew. Even if no one saw. Even if no one applauded.

Most go silent for a long time. Because when you remove the gaze of others, when you remove the comparison, when you remove the approval, many of the things you considered success lose their shine. They do not disappear entirely. But they become... neutral. Weightless. Urgent no longer. Without that compulsive force that was pushing you toward them. And other things, which were never on the list, begin to appear. Smaller things, simpler, quieter. Things the mind dismisses as "that doesn't count" but that the body recognizes as truth.

That is where your true measuring stick begins to emerge. Not the one you were given. Yours. But before you can find it, there is one step you cannot skip: you need to hear the voices. All of them. One by one. And realize that none of them, however familiar they may sound, is yours. Not yet. Because yours is buried beneath all the others. And to find it, you first need to know what it is not.

3. The voices we carry

Imagine that inside you there is a room. A room with many chairs. And in each chair sits a voice. Each voice has a face. Each voice has a history. Each voice has a reason to be there. And all of them, every single one without exception, speak at the same time. From the moment you wake until the moment you fall asleep. And many of them continue speaking while you sleep.

There is the voice of family. It is the oldest of all. It is the one sitting in the chair at the back, the one that arrived first, the one with the most authority, not because it speaks the loudest but because it has spoken since the beginning. The voice of family says things like: "In our family, you work." "In our family, you do not give up." "In our family, you don't talk about money (or you talk obsessively about money)." "In our family, the ones who study succeed." "In our family, those who dream big fall." The voice of family has rules. Rules that are unwritten, unsaid, but implacable. And most women follow those rules their entire lives without ever having consciously formulated them. Because the rules were not said. They were lived. Absorbed. Breathed.

Think about your family. Not about what they said, but about what was lived there. What was celebrated? What was feared? What caused pride? What caused shame? What was permitted to desire and what was forbidden? Was there permission to be different? Was there space to fail without losing love? Was there freedom to want something no one in the family had ever wanted before?

If you answered "no" to any of these questions, you found a voice. A voice that tells you, every day, what you are permitted to want. And what you are not.

Then there is the voice of comparison. This one is more recent than the voice of family, but it compensates in volume for what it lacks in seniority. The voice of comparison arrived at school and has never left. It is the voice that says: "She already has X, and you?" "At her age, she should already have Y." "Look at what she achieved, and with fewer resources than you." The voice of comparison never compares you with someone behind you. It always compares you with someone ahead. Always with someone who has more, does more, shines more. And the conclusion is always the same: it is not enough. You are not enough.

The voice of comparison is especially cruel because it disguises itself as motivation. "It is healthy to have role models. It is good to look at those who do better in order to learn." And yes, it can be. But there is a huge

difference between inspiration and destructive comparison. Inspiration opens you. Destructive comparison closes you. Inspiration says: "How beautiful, this is also possible." Destructive comparison says: "Why don't you do this? What do you lack?"

And you know the difference. You feel it in the body. Inspiration expands. Comparison contracts. Inspiration leaves you energized. Comparison leaves you exhausted. And if you are honest, most of the time you look at social media, at colleagues, at friends, what you feel is contraction. Not expansion.

There is the voice of the era. This is perhaps the most difficult to identify, because it is so broad that it does not seem like a voice. It seems "what everyone knows." The voice of the era tells you that you should be independent (financially, emotionally, professionally). That you should "empower yourself." That you should not need anyone. That you should have a career and a family and a healthy body and a rich social life and a purpose and a personal brand. That you should do all of this with lightness, without complaint, with a smile on your lips and an inspiring phrase in the caption.

The voice of the era is particularly treacherous because it presents itself as freedom. "Today women can do everything." And it is true that our generation has options that our mothers and grandmothers did not have.

But the freedom to be able to do everything has turned, for many women, into the obligation to do everything. And the difference between being able to and having to is the difference between choice and compulsion. And most of the women I know live in compulsion, not in choice. They do everything not because they want to, but because they feel they must. Because the voice of the era tells them that a woman of today does everything. And if she does not, it is because she did not try hard enough.

And there is the voice of "what would look good." This is the most social of all. It is the voice that thinks before acting: "How will this appear?" Not "how will this make me feel?" but "how will this appear to others?" It is the voice that makes you choose the job that impresses instead of the one that ignites you. The home that photographs well instead of the one that comforts you. The partner who "makes sense" instead of the one who makes you feel. The life that seems right instead of the life that is yours.

The voice of "what would look good" is an expert at disguises. It presents itself as maturity ("you cannot live on dreams"), as responsibility ("I have to think about the future"), as pragmatism ("the world is like this"). And yes, maturity, responsibility, and pragmatism exist. But there is a difference between the maturity born of wisdom and the "maturity"

born of fear. True maturity says: "I know what I want, and I will find a way to live it that respects my reality." False maturity says: "I know what I want, but that is not realistic, so I will live what seems right."

Now I want you to imagine all these voices together. The family's, the comparison's, the era's, the "what would look good." All in the same room. All speaking at the same time. All with convincing arguments. All with proof, examples, justifications. All with a version of "success" they present as the correct one.

And somewhere in that room, sitting in the smallest chair, in the quietest corner, is your voice. The one that knows what you truly want. The one that knows what makes you feel alive. The one that knows what you would choose if there were no judgment, no comparison, no expectation. The one that knows what is yours.

But that voice does not shout. It never has. Your true voice is the quietest in the room. Because it does not need to shout. It does not need to convince. It does not need to argue. It knows. It simply knows. But it is buried. Buried under decades of louder, more urgent, more insistent voices. And the woman who lives with all these voices (which is to say, all of us) reaches a point where she genuinely does not know what she

wants. Not because she is indecisive. Not because she lacks intelligence. But because her voice, the true one, is so buried that she can no longer hear it.

I know women who describe this experience as "noise." They tell me: "There is so much noise in my head that I cannot think." And the noise is not disordered thought. It is voices. Voices that are not theirs. Voices that accumulated over years and now speak without stopping, without permission, without invitation.

And the first step is not to silence those voices. That is both violent and impossible. The first step is gentler: it is to recognize that they are voices. That they have an origin. That they came from somewhere. That they were not born with you. Because as long as you think those voices are "reality" or "common sense" or "the way things are," you cannot question them. But from the moment you realize they are voices, that someone placed them there, that they have a history, an origin, a face, something changes. They do not go silent, but they no longer command. Because a voice you recognize as someone else's voice has less power over you than a voice you believe is yours.

There is a woman who told me something that has stayed with me. She said: "I discovered that the voice I thought was my conscience, the one that told me not to give up, to do more, to be better, was not mine. It

was my mother's. I recognized the tone. I recognized the words. I recognized even the speed at which it spoke. And when I saw this, I realized I had never heard my own conscience. Because this voice had occupied that place for as long as I can remember."

This is extraordinarily common. The voices we receive do not present themselves as external. They present themselves as us. They say "I think" when in truth it is "my father thought." They say "I want" when in truth it is "my mother wanted for me." They say "I know" when in truth it is "culture decided." And this is why the work of distinguishing is so delicate: you are not separating things that seem different. You are separating things that seem the same. You are saying: "This that sounds like me, is it really me? Or is it a voice so old that I can no longer tell it came from outside?"

And there is one voice, among all the others, that needs to be seen with special care. Because it is the deepest, the oldest, the most laden with love and with pain at the same time. It is the voice of the family's ambitions. And that is what we need to talk about now.

4. The invisible loyalty to the family's ambitions

This is the most difficult chapter of this book. And probably the most important.

Because the voices we spoke of until now (the school's, the culture's, the social media's, the comparison's) are relatively easy to identify, once you learn to look for them. You can see the influence of culture, you can feel the pressure of social media, you can recognize the mark of school in your beliefs about worth and measurement.

But there is one voice that is different from all the others. Not because it is louder. Precisely because it is quieter. Deeper. More intertwined with you. A voice that did not come through words, but through atmospheres. Not through instructions, but through gazes. Not through orders, but through pains that were never spoken and that you, without knowing, took on as your own.

It is the voice of the unlived ambitions of your family.

I want you to think about your father. Not the father as an abstract figure, but the concrete man. What did he want to be and was not? What did he dream and did not realize? What did life take from him, or what did he not have the courage to go after? What did he sacrifice? And, most importantly: what went unlived in him?

Now think about your mother. The same question. What went unlived in her? What dream was postponed, denied, smothered, buried? What version of herself was she not able to be?

Now look at yourself. At your ambitions, your goals, at what you pursue with the most urgency, the most compulsion, the most inability to stop. And ask, with courage: is this mine? Or am I living what someone in my family could not live?

Family Constellations reveal something that individual psychology does not always reach: families are systems. And in family systems, what is not lived by one generation is frequently transferred to the next. Not as genetic inheritance (although epigenetics is revealing fascinating things about this). But as emotional inheritance. Inheritance of atmospheres. Inheritance of what was left unresolved.

The father who did not study can, without a single explicit word, transmit to his daughter the mission: "Study for me. Realize what I did not realize. Be what I could not be." And the daughter studies. Compulsively. Obsessively. Not because she loves studying, but because something inside her feels she must. That to stop studying would be a betrayal. That not studying would be abandoning her father in his pain. And so she studies. And studies. And does the master's degree. And the doctorate. And the postgraduate degree. And it is still not enough. Because what drives this studying is not curiosity. It is loyalty. And loyalty is never satisfied. Because what the father lost cannot be recovered through the daughter. It lives in a time that has already passed, it belongs to a life that is not hers.

The mother who sacrificed herself can transmit two opposite messages, depending on the family dynamic. She can transmit: "Don't sacrifice yourself the way I did. Do it differently. Be free." And the daughter lives in search of freedom with an urgency that does not feel like freedom: it feels like flight. Because she is not choosing freedom. She is fleeing from her mother's fate. She is living against something, not in favor of herself.

Or she can transmit, unconsciously: "I sacrificed myself for you. The least you can do is be happy." And the daughter carries the obligation to be happy. To be successful. To "be worth" her mother's sacrifice. And that obligation turns every failure into an emotional catastrophe, because failing is not just falling short: it is wasting her mother's sacrifice. It is betraying her suffering. And so the daughter does not allow herself to fail. Never. Because the price is too high.

There are families where success is forbidden. Not explicitly, of course. But implicitly, in subtle and devastating ways. Families where whoever stands out is criticized. Where whoever wants more is accused of arrogance. Where whoever grows is seen as a traitor. "Who do you think you are?" This phrase, said or felt, creates an invisible prison. The daughter who grows up in this family learns that the price of success is the loss of belonging. And because belonging is the most primary need of the human being, she sabotages herself. Unconsciously. She gets close to success and pulls back. She has an opportunity and does not take it. She begins something promising and abandons it. Not for lack of talent. For excess of loyalty. Because succeeding, in that family, is leaving. And leaving is losing love.

And there are families where success is the condition for love. Where affection is not given: it is earned. Where approval is not unconditional: it is a reward for performance. "If you are a good daughter." "If you get good grades." "If you do what I tell you." "If you do not embarrass me." In these families, the daughter learns that love has a price. And the price is being enough. And because "enough" is never defined clearly (because what satisfies the father today does not satisfy him tomorrow), the daughter lives in permanent performance. Always trying. Always proving. Always running to the next demonstration of worth. Because if she stops, she loses love. Or so she feels.

Bert Hellinger, the founder of systemic Family Constellations, taught us a principle that is both simple and shattering: each person in a family system has their place. And when someone occupies another's place (lives the father's dreams, carries the mother's pain, realizes the grandfather's ambitions), they leave their own place. And a person out of their place does not find peace. They may find success, they may find recognition, they may find money. But they do not find peace. Because peace only exists in the place that is ours. And living someone else's life, however much we love them, however much loyalty pushes us, is being out of our own place.

I want to tell you about Teresa (fictional name). Teresa was a lawyer. Brilliant. Competent. Recognized. And miserably unhappy. When we explored her family history, we discovered something she had never formulated: her grandfather was illiterate. He had lived in a rural setting, worked the land his entire life, and died with the sorrow of never having been able to study. Teresa's mother grew up with that sorrow as a backdrop. She studied, yes, but did not reach university. And Teresa, the granddaughter, was the first in the family to have a university degree. And not just any degree: Law. The profession that, in that family, meant "we made it."

Teresa did not choose Law. Law chose her. Or, more precisely, the family system chose her for Law. She carried, without knowing, the ambition of the grandfather who never studied and the frustration of the mother who did not go far enough. And she brilliantly fulfilled the mission. But the mission was not hers. And the brilliance came accompanied by an exhaustion that no weekend resolved, a dissatisfaction that no courtroom victory dispelled, a persistent feeling of living the wrong life without being able to identify what the right one would be.

When Teresa began to see this, she wept. Not from sadness. From relief. Because she finally understood what she felt. It was not ingratitude. It was not weakness. It was being out of her place. It was living her

grandfather's dream in her granddaughter's body. And the body knew. The body always knew. It manifested in migraines before hearings, in insomnia on the eve of deadlines, in stomachaches with no medical cause. The body said, in every way a body can say: "This is not ours."

Recognizing this does not mean rejecting the grandfather. It does not mean despising the mother's sacrifice. It does not mean turning your back on the family. It means, in the language of Constellations, returning to each what is theirs. The grandfather's ambition belongs to the grandfather. The mother's frustration belongs to the mother. And Teresa's life belongs to Teresa. And returning is not abandoning. It is honoring. Because the greatest honor you can give your father is not to live his dreams. It is to live yours. Because when you live yours, you are in your place. And when each person is in their place, the system calms. Everyone finds peace.

But this returning is not simple. It is not a mental exercise done in an afternoon. It is a crossing. Because family loyalties are deep, they are old, they are sewn with threads of love and pain. And undoing those threads without breaking anything requires care, requires time, requires a safe space. It requires more than understanding. And that is what we will continue to talk about.

There is another dynamic I want to name, because it is frequent and rarely spoken about. It is what happens when the daughter surpasses the parents. When the daughter goes further than they went. When she has more money, more education, more freedom, more possibilities. When her life is, in many visible respects, "better" than theirs.

This should be reason for celebration. And often it is, on the surface. The parents say "I am so proud." The family shares photos, tells the neighbors, displays it. But beneath the celebration, there is something more subtle. There is guilt. The guilt of the daughter who surpassed. Because surpassing the parents is, at a deep systemic level, leaving your place. It is, unconsciously, saying: "I can do more than you." And for a daughter who loves her parents, this is intolerable. Because how do I allow myself to have what they never had? How do I allow myself to be free when my mother was not? How do I enjoy a life my father could never have?

And so the daughter does one of two things. Either she sabotages her success (so as not to surpass too much, not to drift too far, to continue to belong). Or she maintains the success but does not feel it (because feeling pleasure in something her parents never had feels like a betrayal).

In both cases, she lives in conflict. She wants to grow but cannot. She wants to have but cannot enjoy. She wants to be free but does not allow herself.

This is the invisible loyalty in its purest form: it does not need words. It does not need orders. It does not need anything explicit. It lives in the family's atmosphere. And the daughter feels it in her body before she thinks it in her mind.

If while reading this chapter you felt something in your body, a contraction, an emotion you did not expect, a desire to cry that has no logical explanation, pay attention. The body is recognizing something the mind has not yet formulated. And that recognition is where everything begins.

5. When the borrowed voice silences yours

There is a phrase I hear frequently. And every time I hear it, I feel the same thing: a mixture of tenderness and anger. Tenderness for the woman who says it. Anger for what was done to her.

The phrase is: "I don't know what I want."

They say it with shame. As if not knowing were more proof of insufficiency. As if all the other women knew (they do not). As if there were something wrong with them for not having a clear, immediate, confident answer.

But "I don't know what I want" is not a defect. It is a symptom. It is the symptom of a woman whose voice was silenced so early, so consistently, so completely, that she stopped hearing it. Not because the voice disappeared. The voice never disappears. But because the other voices, the ones that spoke louder for longer, occupied all the space. And the true voice, without space to express itself, pulled back. It shrank. It hid. And now, when the woman tries to hear herself, she finds silence. Or, worse, she finds the borrowed voices pretending to be hers.

I want to explain how this happens, because it is more subtle than it seems.

When you are a child and have a desire (I want to play, I want to draw, I want to stay here, I don't want to go), and that desire is systematically ignored, minimized, corrected, or punished, something happens. Your system learns that desiring is dangerous. That having your own will generates conflict. That the safest way to exist is to shape yourself to what others want. And so you shape yourself. Not because you are weak. Because you are intelligent. Because adaptation is the most effective survival strategy that exists. And you were a child: surviving was the priority.

But adaptation has a cost. The cost is disconnection. You disconnect from your desires because desiring is dangerous. You disconnect from your emotions because feeling is inconvenient. You disconnect from your body because the body is where all of this lives. And the disconnection, which in childhood protected you, in adulthood imprisons you. Because now you are no longer in danger. Now you can want. Now you can feel. Now you can desire. But the system that learned not to want, not to feel, not to desire, is still active. It is like an alarm that was switched on thirty years ago and was never turned off. The danger passed, but the alarm keeps ringing.

There are concrete signs that the borrowed voice has silenced yours. And I want to name them, because recognizing them is the first step toward reversing them.

The first sign is paralysis before personal choices. The woman who is extraordinarily effective at making professional decisions (she resolves, executes, decides in seconds) but who freezes when someone asks her where she wants to have dinner. Or what she wants to do on the weekend. Or what would make her happy. The professional effectiveness comes from the borrowed voices: the measuring stick is clear, the criteria are defined, she knows what is expected and delivers. But when the question is personal ("what do YOU want?"), the borrowed voices fall silent, because they have no answer for that. And the true voice, silenced for so long, does not respond immediately. And the silence is terrifying.

The second sign is the inability to say no without guilt. If your voice were active, "no" would be natural. "I don't want to." "I don't feel like it." "It's not for me." Clean, clear, no drama. But when your voice is silenced, "no" feels like aggression. It feels like selfishness. It feels like rejection. Because "no" requires you to know what you want (and you

don't) and to value what you want above what others want (and you cannot). So you say yes. Always. To everything. To everyone. And every yes that is not truly yours is another step away from yourself.

The third sign is living by other people's reasons. Choosing the course your parents approve. The job that society respects. The partner the family accepts. The life that "makes sense" in the eyes of those who look. Not out of malice from others. But because, without your own voice, other people's reasons are the only ones you have. They are your default compass. And you follow. Without questioning. Because questioning would require a voice you cannot hear.

The fourth sign, and for me the most revealing, is the body. When the voice goes silent, the body speaks. Because the body is the last refuge of truth. You can silence the mind. You can suppress the emotions. You can rationalize any choice. But the body does not lie. The body contracts when you are doing something that is not yours. The body hurts when you spend too long out of your place. The body gets sick when you ignore its signals for too many years.

How many women do you know with chronic pain that has no medical explanation? How many with persistent fatigue that no test justifies? How many with insomnia, migraines, digestive problems, muscle tension that do not respond to treatment? I am not saying that all illness is

psychosomatic. It is not. But I am saying that the body of a woman who lives out of her place, who carries borrowed ambitions, who follows voices that are not hers, that body is under a constant tension that cannot be explained by workload alone. It is the tension of living a life that is not yours. It is the tension of maintaining a disguise twenty-four hours a day. It is the tension of being who others need you to be instead of who you truly are.

And there is a moment, in the life of many of these women, that functions as a breaking point. It may be an illness. It may be a loss. It may be a crisis at forty (or at thirty, or at fifty). It may simply be a day when they wake up and think: "I cannot do this anymore." Not "I don't want to anymore" (because wanting requires a voice). "I cannot anymore." The body reaches the limit before the mind. And the collapse, which seems like failure, is actually the system's last resort: forcing the woman to stop. Because she will not stop voluntarily. She is too competent for that. Too disciplined. Too loyal to the borrowed voices. So the body decides for her.

If you are at this point, if your body is already asking you to stop, listen to it. Not with your head. With the tenderness you would have for a child. Because that is what your body is doing: it is taking care of the

child within you, the one who lost her voice many years ago and who can now only speak through the body.

And if you have not yet reached that point, if you can still function, if the machine still runs, listen anyway. Because the body gives warning before it collapses. It warns with small signals: the fatigue that does not pass with rest, the disproportionate irritation, the difficulty feeling pleasure in things that once gave you pleasure, the sensation of watching your life from outside. If you recognize these signals, your voice is trying to speak to you. It is trying to tell you that something is not right. That something is not yours. That you are out of your place.

There is an image I use frequently that helps understand this process. Imagine a well. An old, deep well with clean water at the bottom. That water is your voice. And over the years, things were thrown into the well. Expectations, beliefs, fears, rules, other people's voices. Layer upon layer, until the water can no longer be seen. Whoever looks into the well sees only debris. And thinks: "There is no water here." But there is. It is beneath everything. And it is clean. Because the water (your voice) is not contaminated. It stays hidden, yes. But it does not change. It does not disappear. It does not die.

And the good news, the news I want you to take from here, is that the voice did not die. It is alive. It always has been. It is simply buried. And it can be unearthed. Not with force, not with urgency, not with yet another action plan. With gentleness. With patience. With the kind of listening that perhaps no one has ever offered you.

I know women who, when they finally heard their own voice (some for the first time in adult life), described the experience in very similar ways. "It was like coming home." "It was like taking off a mask I didn't know I was wearing." "It was so quiet that I almost didn't notice. But I knew it was true." And it is this quietness that distinguishes the true voice from all the others. The borrowed voices are urgent, noisy, insistent. Your voice is calm. It does not shout. It does not argue. It does not need to convince you. It simply is. And when you hear it, you recognize it. Not because it is familiar (it may not be, if you have never heard it). But because the body relaxes. The tension releases. And something inside you, something very old, sighs with relief.

6. Distinguishing your voice from the others

If you have come this far, you have already seen something important. You have already seen that many of the voices guiding your life are not yours. You have already seen that the measuring stick by which you measure yourself was built by others. You have already seen that the ambitions you pursue may have been born in your family's pain, not in your desire. And you have already seen that your body has been trying to tell you this in every way it can.

Now the natural question arises: how do I distinguish my voice from the others?

I want to be honest with you. I will not give you the complete process here. That process is deep, it is individual, it is a crossing that needs space, time, and accompaniment. That is what the Infante exists for. What I can give you here are clues. Signs. Doors you can push slightly open. Not to walk the path alone, but to begin to feel that the path exists.

The first clue is the body. We have already spoken of it, but I want to give you something concrete. When you are facing a decision (any decision: professional, personal, relational), try this. Imagine option A. Do

not think about it: feel it. Close your eyes if you need to. And notice what your body does. Does it expand or contract? Does it relax or tense? Does it open or close? Now imagine option B. And notice again. The body has its own language, prior to the mind, prior to the voices. And that language is surprisingly reliable, if you learn to hear it. Expansion is a yes. Contraction is a no. Not always, but almost always. And the difference between a decision that expands you and one that contracts you is, very often, the difference between a decision of yours and a borrowed decision.

The second clue is the anonymity test. Ask yourself: if no one knew, would I still do this? If no one saw the result, if no one applauded, if I could not post it on social media, if I could not put it on my resume, if no one knew I had done it, would I still do it? If the answer is yes, there is a good chance it is yours. If the answer is "probably not" or "I am not sure," it is worth asking: for whom am I doing this, then?

I am not saying that everything you do to be seen is false. We are social beings. We want to share, we want to contribute, we want to be recognized. That is human. But there is a qualitative difference between doing something that is yours and sharing it, and doing something only because it can be shared. The first is expression. The second is performance. And performance exhausts in a way that expression does not.

The third clue is the compass of envy. I have spoken of it briefly in an earlier chapter, but it deserves more space. Envy, when it is specific (not the generic kind, not "I want what she has"), is one of the most precise compasses we have. When you see someone do something and feel that sting, that tightening, that "why her and not me?", stop. Do not judge the envy (judging it is another borrowed voice telling you that feeling envy is ugly). Listen to it. What is it in what she did that touches you? It is not the result itself. It is something beneath the result. It is the freedom, perhaps. Or the courage. Or the simplicity. Or the authenticity. And what touches you is exactly what is missing in your life. Not what is missing in hers: what is missing in yours. Specific envy is your voice waving. Saying: "Look! That. That is more like me."

The fourth clue is silence. And this one is simultaneously the simplest and the most difficult. Because silence is the place where your voice can emerge. But it is also the place you avoid most. Because in silence, without tasks, without stimuli, without external voices, what appears are the emotions you have been postponing. The discomfort you have been avoiding. The truth you have been pushing under the carpet. And that is frightening.

But it is necessary. Your voice does not speak when you are busy. It does not speak when you are running. It does not speak when you are reacting. It speaks when you stop. When you become still. When you stop doing and simply are. It does not need to be much. Five minutes. No phone, no to-do list, no plans. Just you and the silence. And probably, in the first few minutes, you will hear nothing. Or you will hear the borrowed voices getting nervous ("you are wasting time," "you should be doing something useful," "this is ridiculous"). Let them speak. Do not respond to them. And wait. Because beneath them, eventually, something quieter begins to stir. Something without urgency. Something that needs no proof. Something that simply knows.

These four clues (the body, the anonymity, the envy, the silence) are not the complete path. They are the beginning. They are the door that opens slightly. And behind that door there is deeper work: distinguishing, voice by voice, what is yours and what is borrowed. Returning to the father what is the father's dream, to the mother what is the mother's pain, to culture what is culture's measuring stick. And keeping only what remains. Which may seem little. Which may seem small. But which is yours. Entirely yours. And what is yours has a quality that nothing borrowed has: it sustains you without exhausting you. It feeds you without consuming you. It moves you without leaving you depleted.

If while reading these clues you felt fear, that is natural. The prospect of questioning everything that has guided your life until now is vertiginous. But you are not destroying anything. You are discovering. You are distinguishing. And distinguishing is not rejecting. It is seeing clearly who belongs to what. So that, finally, you can choose. Not by compulsion. Not by loyalty. Not by fear. By truth.

7. Bridge to the Infante

What this book gave you was a lens. A lens to see something that was so close to your eyes it had become invisible: the voices guiding your life are not all yours.

You saw the measuring stick you never chose. You saw who defined what counts as success. You saw the voices that accumulated (the family's, the comparison's, the era's, the appearance's). You saw the deep loyalty, laden with love, that led you to live ambitions belonging to others. You saw what happens when the borrowed voice silences yours. And you saw the first clues to begin distinguishing.

This is the map.

But a map is not a crossing. Knowing is not the same as transforming. Seeing is not the same as moving. And between recognizing that the voice is not yours and finding the one that is, there is a path that asks for more than reading. It asks for accompaniment. It asks for space. It asks for the kind of silence where your voice can, finally, be heard.

The Infonte was created for that path. Not as yet another program of goals and objectives. But as the space where the question "whose voice is this?" becomes an answer. Where you learn to see, to differentiate, to recognize, to return, to choose by truth, and to occupy, finally, your own place.

And if what you read has revealed to you not only borrowed voices but also emotional weight you carry (guilt, invisible loyalties, repeating patterns you cannot stop), the FreeMe is where that work is done. The Infonte distinguishes what you pursue. The FreeMe liberates what you carry. They are siblings. Both make the same crossing: returning you to yourself.

You will find the Infonte at infonte.viviannedossantos.com. You will find the FreeMe at freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

But before any guided space, stay with the question. Carry it with you. The next time you feel the urgency to run, to prove, to achieve, to be enough, pause for a moment. Breathe. And ask: whose voice is this?

The answer may take time. It may not come in words. It may come as a sensation in the body, as an unexpected emotion, as a silence that finally settles. But it comes. And when it comes, something changes. Because

you stop obeying voices that are not yours. And you begin, perhaps for the first time, to hear the only one that matters.

Yours.

With all my tenderness, *Vivianne*

This material is a self-knowledge and personal reflection resource. It does not constitute therapeutic, psychological, or medical advice. If you feel persistent exhaustion, signs of burnout, or an inability to stop, please seek professional support. The woman who recognizes herself in these pages does too much: recognizing that is strength, not weakness.

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